

divisions—23,000 men—headlong against the heavily defended ridge. It could have been a repeat of Pickett's Charge, the ill-fated Confederate attack at Gettysburg, but instead, eager to redeem themselves from the stain of Chickamauga, the soldiers of the Army of the Cumberland surged over three Confederate trench lines, up the rugged slope of the imposing ridge, and over its summit. They captured much of Bragg's artillery and sent his defenders fleeing to northern Georgia. Watching the assault go forward from their command post, Grant and Thomas were astonished. An angry Grant asked who had ordered the men up the ridge, and Thomas denied that he had done so. Had the men failed, Thomas's career would have ended right there. His troops had prevailed, however, partly because of confusion among Southern soldiers in trenches at the base of the ridge about how many volleys to fire before retreating, and partly because of the poor placement of the Rebel artillery.

Low morale in Bragg's army also had much to do with their defeat. Bragg wrote to Davis after the battle, "The disaster admits of no palliation. I fear we both erred in the conclusion for me to retain command here." Casualties were relatively light for both armies at this point, but the results were clear: Grant had won the battle and opened a path to Atlanta and the Southern heartland.

CRACKER LINE The new supply line to Chattanooga established at the end of October, so called for the hardtack that was the staple of army rations.